

SHALLOW END

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.2

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - DUSK

An outdoor city pool, 1960s bones, sky-blue paint gone chalky. Late August light, long and orange. The water is the only thing here that still looks new.

A WHISTLE – one short blast.

CALLUM (O.S.)
Pool's closed. That's it. Go home.

CALLUM (26), red shorts, zinc on his nose he stopped needing in July, stands on the guard chair like furniture that grew there. The last swimmers slop out. Three TEEN GUARDS are already half-changed, already elsewhere.

TEEN GUARD
Cal. We're out. Dani's thing.

CALLUM
Chairs stacked first.

They stack two of nine chairs and vanish. Callum watches them go through the gate, laughing at something, young in a way that has an expiry he can see and they can't.

He stacks the other seven himself.

MAIN TITLE: SHALLOW END

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - CONTINUOUS

The closing sweep, alone, in order, the same order as always: lane ropes coiled like sleeping snakes. Skimmer run along the surface. Chemical readings into a battered LOGBOOK on a chain – pH, chlorine, temp, and the last column, INCIDENTS: 0.

At the fence, he passes a laminated CITY NOTICE, zip-tied, sun-bleached:

FACILITY WILL NOT REOPEN. AS PART OF THE AQUATIC SERVICES REALIGNMENT, THIS SITE CLOSURES PERMANENTLY SEPT 2.

Under it, in marker, some kid has written: where are we supposed to go. Nobody from the city has answered that either.

Callum clips the gate. Doesn't look back at the water. Looking back is for people with somewhere to be.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - MORNING

Callum unlocks. Fishes one soggy band-aid from the skimmer with the resignation of a priest.

Then he stops.

On the deck, going from the shallow end to the fence: small WET FOOTPRINTS. Dried to ghosts, but there. Size four, maybe five. Bare.

He looks at the fence. Six feet of chain-link with a climbable corner he's reported twice.

He checks the logbook, the water, the night's numbers. Nothing missing. Nothing broken.

He rubs the footprints out with his shoe. Doesn't write it in the book.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT

Black water, holding the streetlight in one long stripe. The pool at night is a different animal – bigger, quieter, breathing.

Callum sits in the dark of the guard chair, hood up, still as the deep end. Waiting.

Ten minutes. Twenty.

Then: the chain-link corner rattles, soft. A small shape drops onto the deck. Stands there. Listens. Crosses to the shallow end like it's done this before.

KAI (12), skinny, all elbows, strips to shorts and lowers himself in at the steps – no splash, practiced, careful.

He pushes off. Three strokes, ugly, urgent – and his rhythm breaks. He grabs for the wall, misses, goes under, comes up coughing, thrashing, close to the edge and completely alone with it –

Callum is already in the water. Two strokes. A hand under the kid's arm, easy, calm, lifting him to the wall.

CALLUM

Feet down. You can stand here.
That's why it's called the shallow end.

Kai stands, chest heaving, mortified, twelve.

KAI
I wasn't drowning.

CALLUM
Okay.

KAI
I was practising.

CALLUM
At midnight. Alone. In a closed pool.

KAI
(the truth, angry with it)
Lessons got cancelled. The city cut them in June. My mum paid and they sent the money back and a letter.

Callum, waist-deep in his clothes, looks at him for a long beat. The streetlight stripe wobbles between them.

CALLUM
I know. I taught them.

KAI
So you got fired and I got a letter. Cool system.

CALLUM
Realigned. We got realigned.

Kai spits pool water over the gutter, twelve years old and completely unimpressed with the English language.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT - DAYS LATER

The gate. Callum's hand clips the padlock – but doesn't push it home. It hangs there, looking locked, being open.

He walks away without looking back at it.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT - SERIES

The pool after hours, lights off, water like poured glass.

- Kai, floating on his back, Callum's hand under him like a shelf, then not there at all. Kai doesn't notice. That's the trick.

- Kick drills at the wall. Callum sits on the deck with his feet in, calling it soft: "Long legs. Boil the water, don't break it."

- Breathing to the side. Kai gets it wrong nine times. The tenth time the night goes quiet around him and he glides.

- Callum doing his chemical readings by phone-light while Kai swims widths behind him. The logbook's INCIDENTS column, night after night: 0. 0. 0.

One night, treading beside him in the deep end's black:

KAI
Who taught you?

CALLUM
Nobody.

KAI
Like me.

CALLUM
No. Not like you.
(beat)
I climbed a fence like you.
Nobody was sitting in the dark
watching. I got to the middle and
the middle got to me. Some guy
walking his dog heard the splash.
(beat)
I've been on that chair since I
was sixteen. People think I never
left. I never stopped checking.

Kai treads water and takes this in the way kids take in the true things – no face at all, filing it forever.

KAI
So the pool almost got you, and
you guard it.

CALLUM
Somebody should.

They don't talk much after that. It isn't that kind of thing. It's the other kind.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - DAY

Daylight. A CITY SURVEYOR in a vest sprays orange dashes on the deck without asking anyone. A CONTRACTOR walks the perimeter tapping the tiles like teeth.

They take the DIVING BOARD off its bolts and carry it out the gate on their shoulders like a coffin nobody paid for. Sold. Callum watches from the chair.

CONTRACTOR
(friendly, leaving)
You the last one here?

CALLUM
Looks like it.

CONTRACTOR
Fill crew's booked for the third.
Good hole, this. Clean sides.

He says it like a compliment. It leaves like one of those doesn't.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT

Kai swims a width, turns, holds the wall. Callum crouches at the deep-end corner, checking the drain cover with a flashlight.

KAI
My cousin says they're gonna put gravel in it. Then dirt. Then grass, like nothing.

CALLUM
That's the order, yeah.

KAI
Where does the water go?

CALLUM
Storm sewer. Then the creek. Then the lake, eventually.

Kai thinks about this with his chin on the tile.

KAI
So it's not gone.

Callum clicks the flashlight off. The stripe of streetlight lies back down on the water.

CALLUM
No. Relocated.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT - LATER

Headlights sweep the fence – a city TRUCK crawling the lot, spotlight lazy. Security check.

Callum kills his phone-light. Kai, in the water, eyes wide. Callum points down. They sink together below the lip of the gutter, two heads in the dark water, holding the wall, holding their breath.

The spotlight drags across the surface, finds nothing but its own reflection, and moves on.

They come up quiet. Kai is grinning so hard it has to hurt.

CALLUM
(whisper)
That never happened.

KAI
(whisper)
Everything here never happened.

Callum looks at him. Twelve years old and already fluent.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - NIGHT - SEPT 1

Last night. The water level is already down a foot – draining slow through valves someone opened at noon. The shallow end is now the very shallow end. The painted 12 FT in the deep end has never looked taller.

Kai stands at the shallow-end wall. Looks the length of the pool. Twenty-five metres of black water to the far side.

KAI
The whole thing. There and touch.

CALLUM
Water's low. You'd be swimming the deep end with nowhere to stand.

KAI
You'll be there.

CALLUM
I'll be here.

KAI
Same thing.

It isn't, and it is, and Callum lets him have it.

Kai pushes off.

Ugly for three strokes. Then long legs. Then the breathing, tenth-try breathing, the glide. Callum walks the deck beside him, matching pace, counting strokes under his breath like a man saying something older than counting.

Past the rope. Over the drop. The bottom falls away under Kai to twelve black feet of nothing and he keeps going –

– and TOUCHES THE WALL.

He comes up with a sound that isn't a word. Callum crouches at the edge. They don't high-five. Kai just holds the gutter and breathes, and Callum nods once, the way men in this film say everything.

CALLUM
Season's over.

KAI
Yeah.

CALLUM
You can swim.

KAI
Yeah.

The water, a foot lower than yesterday, keeps leaving quietly for the lake.

EXT. PUBLIC POOL - DAWN - SEPT 2

Empty. The pool half-drained, the shallow end already beached, wet tiles drying in bands.

Callum, in civvies for the first time in the whole film, does the sweep anyway. Ropes. Skimmer. Habit with nowhere to live now.

At the guard chair he fills in the logbook's last line:

SEPT 1 – pH 7.4 – CL 1.0 – INCIDENTS: 0.

He looks at it. Then, under it, in the margin, small:
taught one kid to swim.

He closes the book and leaves it chained to the chair – for the fill crew, for the gravel, for nobody.

At the gate he stops.

On the other side of the chain-link: KAI. Hood up, school bag on, come to watch it die. Neither of them says anything. The fill trucks idle somewhere behind the fence like weather.

Callum takes the whistle off his neck. Threads it through the diamond of the chain-link, right over "where are we supposed to go" – and lets it go on Kai's side.

Kai puts it on. It hangs to his stomach. He'll grow into it. That's the whole plan, actually.

KAI
Deep end's still got water.

CALLUM
For about an hour.

KAI
So?

Callum looks at the gate. At the padlock in his hand, looking locked, being open. Sixteen years of rules, and one hour of water.

He pushes the gate wide.

CUT TO BLACK.

Over black: two splashes. A beat apart.

THE END